Ship of Theseus

date: 15/04/2026

GAME IDEA

A lone laborer arrives at a half built ship at midnight with one job: replace the broken planks. The work is simple, repetitive and grounding until it isn't. As exhaustion sets in, the ship begins to betray the sense, and what started as a mundane night shift becomes something quietly, deeply wrong.

GAME OBJECTIVE

MAIN OBJECTIVE

To craft short atmospheric experience where mundane repetition becomes the vehicle for dread using the ship of theseus paradox as an emotional undercurrent rather than an explicit theme.

GAMEPLAY GOAL/S

The player should feel the slow creep of unease without ever being certain something is wrong. The ideal reaction when describing it to a friend: "It started boring, then it started messing with me."

PRESENTATION GOAL/S

To build an environment the player trusts just enough so that when it begins to lie, the betrayal lands. quiet dread over jump scares.

GENRE

Single player psychological horror

TARGET AUDIENCE

Fans of games like Amnesia, SOMA or Dredge.

PLATFORM

PC

SUMMARY

The player arrives on a large, half-constructed ship docked somewhere dark and cold. There is no crew, no foreman just a handwritten note: replace the broken planks. Tools are provided. The job is simple.

The early game is almost tediously grounded. The player explores the ship's decks, locates broken or rotted planks, removes them, and replaces them with new timber from a stockpile. The process is tactile and repetitive by design.

As time passes, things begin to slip. A plank the player just replaced appears rotted again. Sounds come from above deck when no one is there. The ship's layout feels subtly different each time the player returns to a section. Nothing is ever confirmed. Nothing is ever explained.

The game ends definitively with a conclusion that reflects how far gone the player's perception has become. The Ship of Theseus paradox is never named outright, but by the end, every plank has been replaced. The question is whether the player has been too.

GAMEPLAY

MECHANICS

- Exploration: Moving throught the ship's multi level environment
- Identification: Broken planks are visually distinct
- Repair: Pry out the broken plank, slot in the new one. Simple, tactile, satisfying.
- Fatigue/Hallucination system: Perception degrades overtime sounds distort, the environment shifts, the layout feels wrong. conveyed entirely through environment, no visible meter.

FEATURES

- Fully first person exploration across a multi deck ship
- A hallucination system that introduces subtle environmental inconsistencies as the game progresses.
- At least two possible endings depending on player behaviour.
- Diegetic UI
- Ambient sound design
- Short runtime (30min-1hr)

PRESENTATION

TEXT

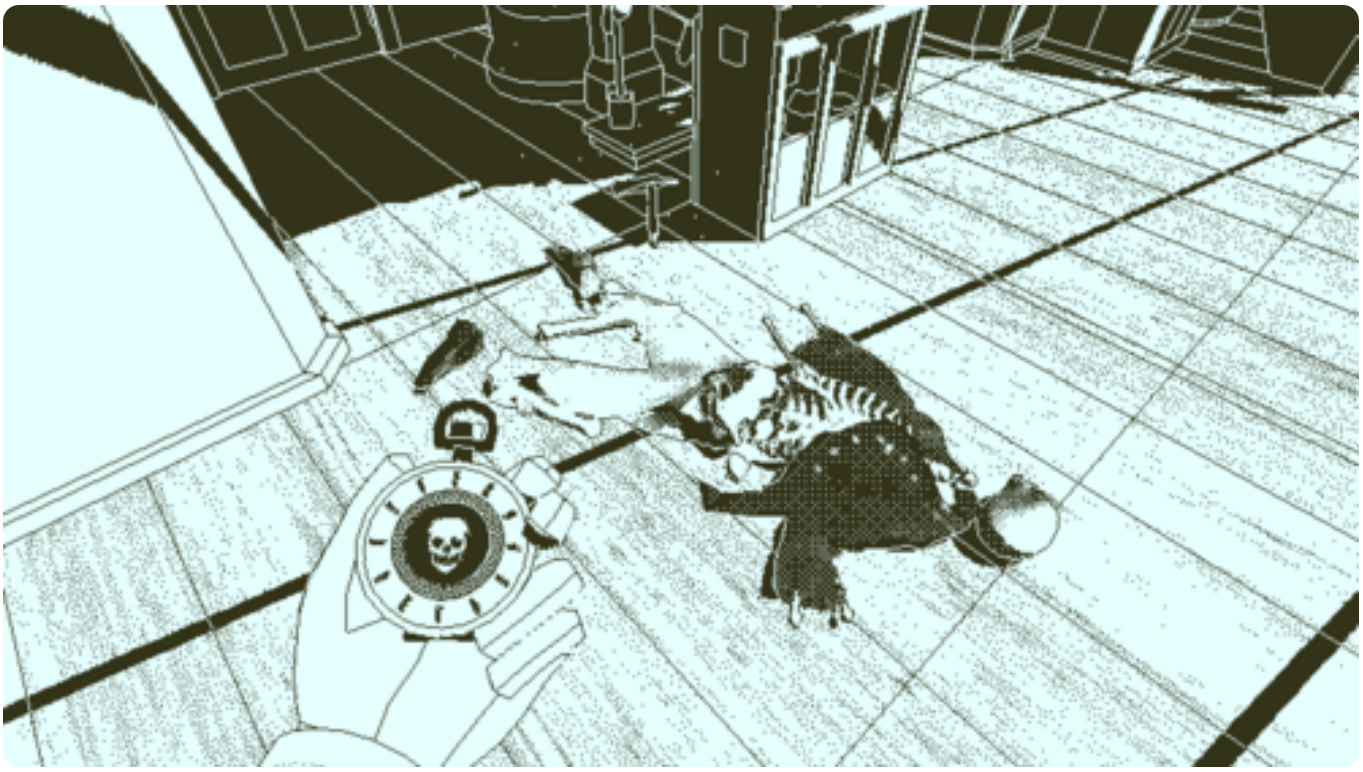
A single handwritten note at the start. Any environmental text(carved into wood, scrawled in grime) is terse and cryptic hinting, never explaining the silence is the tone

VISUAL

Dark and desaturated, Grounded and gritty enough to feel like a real working ship. Inspirations: Amnesia: The Dark Descent, Soma, Dredge.







UI

Diegetic UI Implementation IDEAS

- Fatigue/Mental sanity: Instead of meters, the player's breathing gets audible and heavier. Vision gets subtle vignette.
- Objective: Instead of checklist, the handwritten notes at the start is the objective. If the player forgets the objective, they can re-read it.
- Interaction prompt: Instead of floating "Press E to interact" the characters hand reaches out slightly when facing any interactable - implying readiness.

Non-Diegetic UI IDEAS

- Inventory system: inventory will show items which can be equipped
- Dialogues: player will have monologues about what he is feeling and hints

AUDIO

The audio carries the game. Base soundscape: creaking wood, lapping water, distant wind, the scrape of labor. As the player deteriotes, these sound warp, the creak becomes whisper, footsteps echo wrong, the water sounds too close. music is near absent early on, late game introduces dissonant drones felt as much as heard.

Hallucination Inspirations

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https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oi2kWVML-kA